

WIVES AND workers

ANCIENT IRAN

The first Persian Empire, known as the Achaemenid empire, was founded by Cyrus II in 550 BCE and lasted until Alexander the Great defeated the Persians in battle in 331 BCE. The kings of Ancient Persia were polygamous, and their wives lived within a strict hierarchical structure headed by the king's mother and his main wife, who was likely the mother of his named heir. Elite women lived together in a household that some historians called a harem—a term also used to describe the women themselves. In addition to wives, Persian kings also took concubines, who came to court as war captives or tribute gifts. A king's polygamy served a major political purpose. His wives produced children—sons to inherit the throne or become governors, and daughters to marry high-ranking courtiers and local dynasts. Polygamy was therefore integral to the rule of the Achaemenids, helping to ensure the king's continuing authority across his empire.

▼ Adorned in gold

Men and women alike wore lavish jewelry and makeup. This earring depicts the Persian god Ahura Mazda and "Bounteous Immortals," three of whom were female.



◀ Commemorated in blue

This bust made from lapis lazuli—a precious blue stone—is thought to depict a prince, eunuch, or woman of the Achaemenid period.

Shiraz), had groups of up to 480 people in her employ. Irdabama's seal on records for dispensing wine, grain, flour, and barley shows that not only did she feed her workers from her own estates, but that she also took an active role in the administration of her financial affairs.

Workers and rations

The Persepolis texts also include lists of rations allocated to various workers, explicitly recording their sex. One type of worker appeared to earn more than any other: a female *arraššap* (chief) received 30 quarts of wine, 50 quarts of barley, and meat each month. Women with this title were even occasionally mentioned by name in the records, leading scholars to believe they were important. Such women were in charge of large groups of workers called *pašap*, and the texts show that, in these groups, men and women received equal pay for doing the same job. Records from a distributor named Iršena, for example, show that male and female attendants were both given 40 quarts. However, not all women were so fortunate. Within a group of workers known as *harrinup*, some women earned just two-thirds of what their male counterparts did for the same work. However, after childbirth, both *harrinup* and *pašap* women seem to have been supported by employers; they were provided with extra food rations (called *kamakaš*) for the following month, suggesting that the Achaemenids placed some value on mothers even outside of elite circles.

Powerful landowners

Records of women's estates survive in cuneiform texts found at Persepolis, the ceremonial capital of the empire, which allow a glimpse into life in the ancient Persian world. Evidence from these texts suggests that elite women had a degree of economic independence, and could amass great amounts of land and personal property. One such woman was a particularly wealthy landowner named Irdabama, who the texts reveal oversaw vast personal estates. She received and distributed food supplies, and commanded a huge entourage of workers. Her largest workforce, at Tirazziš (near